

LITTLE SPROUT STORIES

James & Marcus by the River

A story about a small worry — and a day saved by a friend's quick hands



James and Marcus carried the red picnic basket between them — one handle each, the way you carry something precious — down the grassy path to where the river sparkled and chuckled over its stones. It was a warm spring day, the kind with butterflies in it. “Best picnic spot in the world,” Marcus announced, “here we come!”

James and Marcus go to the river.



Down by the green shore, a small wooden rowboat bobbed and nodded on the ripples, bumping its nose softly against the dock — hello, hello, hello. Sunlight danced on the water in a thousand tiny coins. “Look at that little boat!” laughed Marcus. “It’s like it’s waving at us.”

Marcus sees a little boat on the water.



“A good picnic starts before the basket even opens,” said James, who had thought about this picnic all week. First, the big checkered blanket, spread smooth under the shady willow tree. Then a check of the spot together: soft grass, no anthills, close enough to watch the water and far enough to keep their toes dry. Hats on, water bottles out. “Ready,” James nodded, satisfied. “NOW we’re ready.”

First we get ready. Then we picnic.



Before eating, the boys explored the river’s edge, where the world was busy being small. Smooth stones, cool as coins. A dragonfly in a jewel-blue coat, hovering like a tiny helicopter. Rings spreading on the water where fish mouths kissed the surface — plip, plip. “There’s so much happening,” Marcus whispered, “in the part I almost didn’t look at.”

Many small things live by the river.



“Let’s play the quiet watching game,” said James. “Whoever sits stillest, sees most.” So they sat — wiggle-free, whisper-quiet — and practiced being watchers. One minute of stillness, and the river began to trust them: a frog plopped, a heron stalked past on stilts of legs, and two dragonflies chased each other in loops. “Watching,” said Marcus, amazed, “is harder than running. And better.”

Sit still and watch. The river shows you things.



The river, they were learning, isn’t just water going past. It’s somebody’s whole home. The fish live under the ripples, the ducks paddle on top, the dragonflies hunt above it, and the old willow drinks from it with roots like straws — and in return, her shade keeps the bank cool for everybody. Everything here helps everything else. “It’s not our river,” James said slowly. “We’re just visiting it.”

The river is a home for many animals.



Not far away, Alex the firefighter sat fishing, as peaceful as a cat in a sunbeam. “River rules, since you’re visiting,” he called with a grin. “One: stay where a grown-up can see you — look at the water with your eyes, not your feet. Two: everything we bring, we bring back — wrappers, bottles, all of it. The river gives us a beautiful day. We give it a clean bank back.”

Stay where grown-ups can see you. Keep the river clean.



At last, the picnic! Marcus lifted the lid with a flourish — but the jam jar, slick and round and heavier than it looked, slipped right through his fingers. Down it tumbled toward the stones — “Oh no!” he cried, and his stomach dropped right along with it. “Did it spill? Did I ruin the picnic?”

Marcus is sad. “Did the jar spill?”

Where did James and Marcus go for a picnic?

- ◯ By the quiet river
- ◯ To the moon
- ◯ Inside a dark cave



But the jar never hit the stones. Quick as a frog’s tongue — snap! — Alex’s hand shot out from his fishing spot and caught it clean, with a friendly grin. “Safe and sound!” said Alex. “Slippery jars are nobody’s fault, Marcus. They’re just jars being jars.” Marcus let out all the breath he’d been holding. The picnic — and the day — were saved.

Alex smiles. “I got it!”



Then they shared everything properly at last: fresh bread torn into pillowy hunks, sweet fruit that ran down their chins, cool water, and — of course — great shining spoonfuls of the rescued jam. Somehow, food tastes better outside, with grass under the blanket and somebody you like across from you. “To the jar,” James toasted, raising his cup. “And to the catch.”

They eat bread and jam together.

Who helped Marcus catch the jar?

- ◯ Alex the helper
- ◯ A flying bird
- ◯ A giant bear



Two friendly ducks came paddling over, quacking hopeful quacks, and Marcus waved them a royal welcome. They didn’t get any jam — jam is not for ducks, Alex explained, because wild animals do best with their own wild food — but they stayed for the company anyway, bobbing just offshore. “Picnics with friends are the best,” sighed Marcus. “Even the floating kind.”

Ducks come to visit the picnic.



As the sun slid low and painted the water gold, the boys packed their basket the Alex way: everything they brought, they brought back — every wrapper, every bottle, until the bank looked as clean as a bedtime story’s last page. Then they waved to the boat, the willow, and the whole shining river. “Good day!” they called. And the river, chuckling over its stones, seemed to wave back.

James and Marcus say, “Good day, river!”



■ River Friend

Great reading!

For Grown-Ups

Feeling/skill: Outdoor curiosity, sharing, and helping a friend.

Ask your child: Have you ever shared a meal outside with someone? What was fun about it?

Try this: Have a mini living-room or backyard blanket picnic together this weekend.

Words to grow on: sparkled, bobbed, ripples, checkered, observe, stillness, ecosystem, stewardship, rescued. Point at the river's residents as you name them — dragonfly, heron, frog, willow, ducks.

The bigger picture: A picnic is the smallest part of this story. The boys prepare carefully, practice the skill of quiet observation, discover that a river is a whole community of living things that help each other, and learn the two kindnesses of visiting wild places: stay safe, and leave the place cleaner than you found it.

Standards: RL.K.1, SL.K.3

The End — thanks for reading!